

METAL TOOLS

By around 3500 BCE, people in Europe, Asia, and Africa were using metal. This was a far better material than stone because it was easier to shape and work with and kept a sharper edge. At first, metalworkers used copper and bronze, but from 1200 BCE they started to use iron. Metal could be used to make many things, including weapons, armor, agricultural equipment, jewelry, nails, and cooking pots.

WOW!

The earliest stone tools, known as the “Oldowan toolkit,” are 2.6 million years old. They were found in the Olduvai Gorge in Africa.

Copper blade bound to a wooden shaft with leather strings

Prehistoric copper ax

Bronze cutting edge

Bronze Age sickle

Iron Age sickle

This sickle would have been attached to a wooden handle.

► FARMING TOOLS

While sickles were commonly used for harvesting cereal crops, axes were used to clear forested areas for farming. These three examples show copper, bronze, and iron tools.

MELTING AND MIXING

Before metals can be made into anything, they have to be “smelted.” In this process, metal ores (rocks that naturally contain metal) are heated over a very hot fire to remove unwanted substances. Once people had found out how to extract metals, they went on to discover that mixed metals could create a stronger material, called an alloy. The first alloy invented was bronze, which was made by adding tin to copper.

High heat beneath pan of ore separates out copper.

Bellows